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ARTICLE

Revival By The Sea: Jacksonville Baptism Event Draws Thousands



BY PNW STAFF MAY 22, 2026

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On the shores of Jacksonville this past weekend, something extraordinary happened. In a culture that constantly tells us Christianity is fading, outdated, or losing the next generation, more than 2,500 people walked into the Atlantic Ocean and publicly declared that Jesus Christ is Lord.

It was not a political rally. It was not a celebrity concert. It was not driven by entertainment, outrage, or social media trends.

It was baptism.

And it may be one of the clearest signs yet that beneath the surface of America's cultural chaos, a spiritual hunger is growing.

At Hanna Park in Jacksonville, Florida, The Church of Eleven22 reported that 2,552 people were baptized during its massive beach gathering. More than 14,000 people reportedly attended the event, filling the beach with worship, prayer, celebration, and tears of joy as thousands publicly professed their faith in Christ.

In an age where many churches struggle just to keep attendance steady, the image of thousands lining the shore to witness baptisms felt almost like a scene pulled from the Book of Acts.

One by one, people entered the water declaring that their old life was gone and that they had been made new in Christ. The church described baptism not as the source of salvation, but as "the outward sign of an inward spiritual reality" — a public declaration that a person has been united with Jesus in His death and resurrection.

That distinction matters.

In a time when faith is often reduced to vague spirituality, self-help slogans, or political identity, these baptisms pointed back to the core message of the Gospel: repentance, surrender, transformation, and new life through Jesus Christ.

Perhaps one of the most powerful moments of the day came at the very end. According to the church, the final person baptized was one of the shuttle bus drivers helping transport attendees to the event. After spending the day watching thousands profess faith, something stirred in his heart, and he too stepped into the water.

"Only God could write a story like that," the church said afterward.

Indeed, only God can turn a beach into a sanctuary and an ordinary workday into a divine appointment.

What makes this even more remarkable is that this was not a one-time anomaly. The Church of Eleven22 has seen a stunning pattern of growth in recent years. Nearly 2,000 people were baptized during last year's beach event, and more than 1,600 the year before that. Instead of fading, the movement appears to be accelerating.

Pastor Joby Martin summarized it best when he declared, "The church is alive and well, the Spirit of God is on the move, and the gospel of Jesus Christ is still changing lives today."

That message could not come at a more important time.



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Americans are constantly bombarded with headlines about moral decline, cultural confusion, loneliness, addiction, depression, and hopelessness. Surveys show trust in institutions collapsing. Young people especially are searching for meaning in a world filled with anxiety and instability.

Yet moments like this remind us that God has not abandoned this nation.

While much of the media focuses exclusively on stories of deconstruction and unbelief, there is another story unfolding quietly across America — a revival hunger that is beginning to emerge in churches, college campuses, and communities hungry for truth.

Over the past few years, there have been signs of this spiritual awakening in unexpected places. The spontaneous worship gatherings at universities such as Asbury University captured national attention. Large-scale baptisms have erupted across multiple states. Churches that boldly preach the Gospel are often seeing renewed growth, particularly among younger believers searching for authenticity and biblical truth.

And perhaps that should not surprise us.

Historically, revival often begins during moments of deep uncertainty. Throughout Scripture and church history, spiritual awakenings have frequently emerged during periods of cultural darkness, national anxiety, and moral collapse. When the world grows cold and unstable, many begin searching for something eternal.

That is exactly why this moment in Jacksonville matters.

Those 2,552 baptisms were not just numbers. Every single one represented a story — a broken marriage being restored, an addict finding freedom, a prodigal returning home, a young person discovering purpose, a weary soul finally encountering grace.

The world may look at a beach baptism and see emotion or symbolism. But Christians understand something deeper is taking place. Baptism is a declaration that Jesus still saves. That hearts can still change. That redemption is still possible.

And in a cynical age increasingly defined by division and despair, that is news worth celebrating.

For all the warnings about America's spiritual decline, Jacksonville just offered a powerful reminder: the Gospel is still changing lives, the church is still standing, and God is still drawing people to Himself — one soul at a time.

You can celebrate with them by watching here:

'JESUS TAKEOVER': THOUSANDS baptized at Florida beach event

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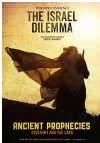
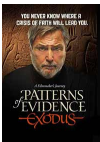
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